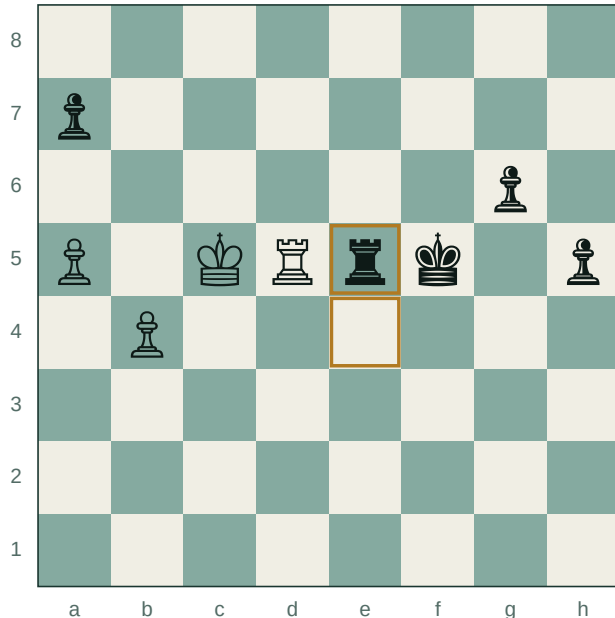


Active defensive resources: White, move 53

Active defensive resources

White to move



Previous move: 52...Re5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

53. Rxe5+ Kxe5 54. b5

53.Rxe5+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on e5. Recorded reply: **53...Kxe5**.

54.b5 The pawn moves from b4 to b5.

At the end, nominal material is White 2 / Black 3 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from -1 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on f5. Absolute pin: rook on e5.